

A Thin Veiled Night

Pen Argyl

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EXT. CAMPFIRE RING - NIGHT

A poker leans against a rock. The near end of the fire has gone gray. Coals under that gray still hold a little heat, but the flame has pulled back toward the middle of the ring.

NARRATOR (grown, years after that Halloween) sits close enough to feel the heat on their knees. They lift the poker and dig the gray end open until orange shows again. Sparks climb and die.

Across the ring, a few faces wait. Nobody rushes Narrator.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Hand me that poker, would you.
This end of the fire's gone gray,
and I want it going good before I
tell this one, because in this one
the fire ends up the most
important thing in the yard.

Narrator sets the poker back against the rock and wipes ash off their fingers on their jeans.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

I grew up in Pen Argyl, up in the
Slate Belt, where the roofs are
slate and half the old sidewalks
are slate and the quarry holes sit
back in the woods full of green
water so deep nobody's ever
touched bottom. In October of 2021
I was thirteen.

CUT TO:

EXT. PEN ARGYL STREET / SLATE SIDEWALK - DAY (OCTOBER 2021)

The roofs are slate, and the cracked walk out front is slate. October leaves stick wet against the curb. Porch flags hang leftover from a year when Halloween never really happened.

Kids cut across yards toward a brick house with a basement walkout and a fire pit in the side yard, already stacked with a few split logs for later.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

We'd lost a whole year of Halloween to the virus, and that fall every kid in town wanted a party, so Tyler Morgan's mother said fine, the basement, and she'd be upstairs.

INT. TYLER'S BASEMENT - NIGHT

A dehumidifier ticks in the corner. A cheap pumpkin candle sits on the dryer and throws a flat orange circle on the wall. A bowl of candy corn waits on a folding table; nobody has touched it. On the TV, an old monster movie plays with the sound off. A werewolf mouth opens and closes in silence.

TYLER MORGAN (13) sits on the carpet with his back against the wall. His cousin BRANDON (19) sits cross-legged near the furnace in a hoodie, a long flat store box beside his knee.

NARRATOR comes down the stairs carefully around a laundry basket of folded towels left on the third step. They take a spot with their knees up and their back on the washing machine.

INT. CHURCH / BAPTISM TANK - DAY (FLASHBACK - JULY 2021)

A big tank behind the pulpit. DANNY HESS (17) comes up out of the water with his hair sticking straight up. Water runs off his chin. The room claps. KAYLEIGH HESS (14) stands in the aisle with her arms folded, half embarrassed and half proud.

EXT. CHURCH PARKING LOT - DAY (FLASHBACK - CONTINUOUS)

Danny shakes water out of his ear. Narrator and Kayleigh stand with him between parked cars. Danny's shirt sticks to his shoulders.

DANNY

If anything ever happens to me,
I'm with Jesus. You two know where
I'll be.

Kayleigh rolls her eyes at him the way a little sister does
when her brother gets soft in public.

DANNY (CONT'D)

You hear me, Bug.

KAYLEIGH

Don't call me that out here.

Danny laughs anyway. He towels his hair with the hem of his
shirt.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Three weeks before he died he got
baptized at my church. He drowned
in the Albion hole that July, on a
Sunday afternoon, jumping off the
high ledge with his friends.

INT. TYLER'S BASEMENT - NIGHT (OCTOBER 2021)

Kayleigh comes down the stairs around the towel basket. She
has cat ears clipped in her hair and a black sweatshirt on.
She carries her phone.

She drops onto the carpet near Narrator. Tyler says hey
without looking up.

Brandon slides the long flat box into the middle of the
circle and peels the lid. Inside sits a talking board with
the alphabet arched across the top, a sun painted in one
corner and a moon in the other, and a cheap plastic heart
balanced on three little pads. It's store-bought, as plain
as any board game.

BRANDON

It's a game. They sell it at
Target.

He sets the board on the carpet and rests the plastic heart on the letter A like he's dealing cards.

Six kids sit around it.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

I'll tell you the truth. I didn't put my fingers on the heart, but I didn't leave either. I wanted to see. That's how it gets you. All it asks is that you stay.

For a while it is dumb. Brandon's fingertips ride the heart and spell a girl's name from school. Everybody screams and laughs. Candy corn stays untouched. The silent werewolf keeps chewing air on the TV.

Brandon puts on a spooky voice he thinks is funny.

BRANDON

Is anybody here who wants to talk to somebody here?

The heart slides to YES and locks there hard, the way a cart freezes when one wheel snags on a crack.

Brandon takes his hands off it. The heart stays on YES.

Then it moves again under only two girls' fingertips. Neither girl is pushing. Both faces have gone as white as the candle wax.

The heart stops on B. Then U. Then G.

Kayleigh sits back on her heels.

The two girls snatch their hands away. The little heart keeps drifting on its own, slow, over the slick board.

Letters gather under it:

COLD.

ALONE.

IN THE WATER.

COME SEE ME BUG.

Kayleigh's mouth opens. Her eyes fill up all at once. She reaches for that plastic heart with both hands the way somebody grabs for a sleeve in a crowd.

The heart keeps going.

ALBION.

MIDNIGHT.

COME.

Brandon stands up and backs into the furnace. Somebody starts crying. The candle on the dryer burns straight up, not a flicker. The dehumidifier clicks off by itself.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

My grandmother used to say the devil shows up with your name in his mouth. I hadn't understood her until that night.

Narrator looks at the board, then at Kayleigh's hands reaching for it.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

What I understood right then was simpler. I'd been in that church parking lot with water dripping off Danny Hess's chin. I'd heard him say it. Danny wasn't cold, and he wasn't alone, and he wasn't in the water. Whatever was pushing that plastic heart around knew a nickname, and it lied about everything else.

Narrator's knees shake so bad Narrator has to brace their palm on the washing machine to stand. Narrator's voice comes out small. They make it bigger.

NARRATOR
Kayleigh, don't touch it.

Kayleigh's hands freeze over the heart.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)
Danny's with Jesus. You were
standing right there when he told
us. That's not Danny.

The heart jerks to NO, then hammers BUG again and again, fast. The girls closest to the board crawl backward on the carpet.

Narrator does not argue with it. They step over two kids and plant their sneaker flat on the board, full weight.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)
In the name of Jesus Christ, you
get out of this house and you
leave her alone.

They do not say it pretty. They say it like yelling at a dog going for a baby. Their knees keep shaking under them.

The heart quits. Under Narrator's toe it is only cheap plastic again. The candle flame tips sideways and rights itself. Upstairs, through the floorboards, Tyler's mother's TV comes back: a game show and an audience clapping. Nobody in the basement can say when that sound went missing.

Narrator takes Kayleigh by the wrist.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)
Come on.

The two of them run.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

The Bible calls that fleeing, and
there's no shame in it.

INT. TYLER'S HOUSE / STAIRS AND HALL - CONTINUOUS

Narrator pulls Kayleigh up the stairs past the towel basket. TYLER'S MOM stands in the hall in a bathrobe with a remote in her hand and the game-show laugh track loud behind her. She opens her mouth to ask a question. Narrator and Kayleigh are already past her toward the side door.

EXT. TYLER'S YARD / FIRE PIT - NIGHT

Cold October air. A few logs already going in the fire pit for the little kids. Narrator and Kayleigh stand in the heat with their breath showing. Kayleigh shakes so hard her cat ears fall off in the grass. Narrator does not pick them up yet. Narrator keeps hold of her wrist until her shaking slows.

Tyler comes out a minute later carrying the board under one arm and the plastic heart clenched in his fist.

TYLER
What do I do with it.

TYLER'S DAD steps out from the porch light. He is a Slate Belt man who grew up in a church basement himself. He takes in the board under Tyler's arm, Kayleigh still shaking, Narrator still holding her wrist. He does not ask a single question.

He takes the board from his son and snaps it over his knee. The crack is loud, like a shingle tearing off a roof. He sets the broken pieces on the burning wood. Painted sun and moon brown and blacken as they curl. Letters cook off one at a time.

Tyler throws the heart in after the wood. The plastic shrinks to a bubble and a bad smell.

Brandon stays on the porch with both hands buried in his hoodie pocket. He watches the burn and keeps his mouth shut.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

And that was the right thing for
him to say.

Narrator finally bends and picks Kayleigh's cat ears out of the wet grass. Kayleigh takes them without putting them back on.

INT. KAYLEIGH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (LATER)

A flashlight rests on the floor between a sleeping bag and the bed frame. Narrator lies on the floor beside Kayleigh's bed. Kayleigh sits up against the headboard with her knees under the blanket.

KAYLEIGH'S MOTHER comes in with cocoa in two mismatched mugs. One mug carries a fire-company carnival logo. She sets both on the nightstand, looks at the two of them once, and leaves without asking anything.

The clock on the nightstand passes midnight. Both of them are still awake.

Narrator opens a Bible on the floor in the flashlight beam and holds it open to Second Corinthians.

NARRATOR

Paul says that to be away from the
body is to be at home with the
Lord.

Kayleigh listens with both hands around her mug.

KAYLEIGH

Say it again.

Narrator says it again in the same plain voice. Around three, Kayleigh falls asleep holding the edge of Narrator's blanket. The flashlight stays on until the battery fades to a dull orange and then Narrator clicks it off.

INT. CHURCH - DAY (SPRING 2022)

It's the same church, and the tank behind the pulpit is dry now. KAYLEIGH sits in her old row. Narrator sits beside her. Neither of them looks at the tank.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

That spring she started coming to church with me. She sat in the same row where she'd watched her brother go under the water. She never asked me what was talking through that board, and I never told her what I think. I'll tell you what I know. It knew one little word, and it used that word to try to walk a grieving girl to the edge of a quarry in the dark. Kayleigh's a nurse now, up at the hospital in Easton. Neither one of us has touched one of those boards since.

EXT. CAMPFIRE RING - NIGHT (BACK TO PRESENT)

Narrator lifts a split log and lays it on the gray end they opened at the start. Flame takes it. Heat comes back into their face. Sparks climb and die the ordinary way.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Go on, throw that log on. Get it high. I like a fire in October that's just a fire, for warming hands and cooking hot dogs and lighting up faces, and nobody's calling anybody to come sit by it but us.

FADE OUT.